

and smaller constructions are built around the main palace in a star shaped pattern. Earlier attacks have left holes in the large walls surrounding the complex allowing me to see into the estate. It was obviously a beautiful place, and it appears that despite the economic hardship of the Iraqi people, Saddam did not feel the bite of the economic sanctions.

Speaking of the elite in Iraq, one of our adjacent units found Uday Hussein's home a few days ago. While I didn't see the house, the unit did report quite an array of luxury there too. First of all, Lt. Collins and I were drooling as we heard the report that the Leader unit located a plethora of luxury and sports cars at Uday's home. The cars began with a brand new Honda S-2000 (the cheapest) and ranged all the way to a Porsche 911 Twin Turbo and Ferrari Testarossa. They also found millions of dollars in gold and cash in the house. Once again, I doubt he suffered too much under the economic sanctions.

Today, I am working on a Brigade Update Brief for Major Cribb. It appears that the 1st Armor Division will be here soon, and they will begin to replace the 3rd Infantry Division (the unit that we are once again attached to). We don't really know what this means for us. We know that 3ID will be headed home, and we hope that we will be with them. We have heard rumors that President Bush wants all the units who fought the war to return home by July 4, but we don't know anything for sure. Right now we are completing our plans to move to the northern portion of Baghdad where we will patrol a new zone.

Our current operations consist mainly of locating downed and damaged power lines, water mains and other public works facilities. Our Field Artillery guys have been magically transformed into Civil Affairs representatives and spend most of the day searching out local leaders so that we can begin establishing a transitional government. As for me, and life in the TOC, everything is fairly mundane. We are not startled by the random explosions set off by our Engineers as they remove unexploded ordnance around the city. Unfortunately the only thing that breaks the routine here now, is the almost daily reports of civilians—mainly children—that are injured playing with the bright yellow and blue bomblets of unexploded artillery shells or Air Force munitions. It is always a sad affair.

In the last week we have had three children in our area seriously injured by munitions that litter the streets and alleyways in the aftermath of the fighting. Two children died and one has been evacuated, treated, and is expected to recover. The most dramatic incident occurred here yesterday when two children were playing, exploring, or just rummaging in the field adjacent to our headquarter. We think they may have been looking for bricks to take home when the entire complex was rocked by a huge explosion. Since we are virtually immune to this now, no one thought about it too much at first. It was only a short time afterwards, when the guards were frantically calling for the medics, that we realized the explosion was not merely one of the many Engineer operations. The result was a mad rush to the front gate. The Sergeant Major, the Military Intelligence Officer, and a slew of others rushed out to see what had happened. Two teenagers had been exploring the dirt field when an Air Force munition we didn't know about exploded, tearing one of the boys in two. The second boy was fine. How can you explain that?